keySkillset

AWS SES Email Design Rulebook

Signup, Welcome & Onboarding Emails — HTML Best Practices, SES Limits, Dark Mode, Accessibility & Deliverability

Version 1.0 | April 2026 | Internal Use Only | Companion to Salesforce Email Design Rulebook

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1. Purpose & Scope

This rulebook governs all HTML emails sent through AWS Simple Email Service (SES) at keySkillset — specifically signup, welcome, and onboarding emails triggered by user actions in the product. It is a companion to, and does not replace, the Salesforce Email Design Rulebook v2.0.

What is in scope for this document:

- Signup confirmation emails
- Welcome / onboarding emails
- Account activation and set-password emails
- Any HTML email sent programmatically via the AWS SES API or SMTP interface

What is out of scope:

- List Email / Campaign Email sends — covered in the Salesforce Rulebook v2.0
- Flow-triggered transactional emails sent through Salesforce — covered in the Salesforce Rulebook v2.0

Key difference from Salesforce: AWS SES sends raw MIME email directly to the recipient's mail server. There is no Salesforce tracking wrapper, no 32,000-character hard wall, no Content Library dependency, and no Salesforce merge field syntax. The email client rendering constraints (Outlook, Gmail, dark mode) still apply in full because those are client-side problems, not send-platform problems.

2. How AWS SES Differs From Salesforce — At a Glance

Before building any AWS SES email, every developer and designer must understand which constraints change and which remain identical. This table is the fastest way to orient yourself.

Constraint	Salesforce	AWS SES
HTML size limit	Hard 32,000-char limit for List Email. Salesforce tracking adds 5–10K on top.	No equivalent hard limit. Gmail still clips at 102 KB file size. Practical target: keep under 80 KB.
Size headroom	Target under 25,000 chars to leave room for tracking wrapper.	Target under 80 KB file size. No character-count wall.

Constraint	Salesforce	AWS SES
Template engine	Salesforce merge fields: {{{Field_Name}}}. Resolved server-side by Salesforce.	Handlebars syntax: {{variable}}. Resolved at send time by SES API. Supports conditionals, loops, partials.
Image hosting	Must use Salesforce Content Library. External URLs may be blocked.	Any publicly accessible CDN or S3 URL. No Content Library requirement.
Tracking wrapper	Salesforce adds tracking markup that inflates your file size by 5–10K.	No automatic tracking wrapper. Add UTM parameters manually to links if analytics are needed.
Daily send limit	5,000 emails/day org-wide (shared with all Salesforce bulk sends).	Starts at 200/day (sandbox). Production accounts scale on request. No fixed daily cap once out of sandbox.
Template management	Templates managed in Salesforce Setup > Classic Email Templates.	Templates stored via AWS SES CreateEmailTemplate API. No UI — developer-managed.
Outlook rendering rules	Same — Outlook uses Word's engine regardless of send platform.	Same — Outlook uses Word's engine regardless of send platform.
Gmail clipping	Same — Gmail clips at 102 KB regardless of send platform.	Same — Gmail clips at 102 KB regardless of send platform.
Dark mode behaviour	Same — client-side rendering applies regardless of send platform.	Same — client-side rendering applies regardless of send platform.
SPF / DKIM / DMARC	Configured on Salesforce sending domain.	Must be configured separately on your SES sending domain. SES makes DKIM setup straightforward.
Bounce / complaint mgmt	Salesforce handles bounce tracking via its own reporting.	Must wire SNS notifications to a Lambda or webhook to catch bounces and complaints and feed your suppression list.
Unsubscribe requirement	Required by CAN-SPAM / GDPR in marketing emails.	Transactional emails (signup, welcome) are not legally required to include unsubscribe, but must not be deceptive.

3. AWS SES Limits & Quotas

These are the hard limits that apply to keySkillset's AWS SES account. Unlike Salesforce's fixed 32K wall, most SES limits are adjustable by requesting a quota increase via the AWS Service Quotas console.

Limit	Value	Notes
Max email size (SES API v2)	40 MB	Includes message body, HTML, images, and attachments. MIME encoding adds ~37% to raw file sizes. Keep well under this.
Max email size (SES API v1)	10 MB	Legacy API only. Use v2 for all new integrations.
Gmail clipping threshold	102 KB	Gmail clips HTML at 102 KB and shows "View entire message". Target under 80 KB to be safe.
Sandbox sending limit	200 emails / 24 hrs	Applies before production access is granted. Request production access via AWS Support.
Sandbox sending rate	1 email / second	Applies in sandbox only. Production rate is higher and adjustable.
Max bounce rate (warning)	5%	AWS warns at this threshold. Sending may be paused if rate continues rising.

Limit	Value	Notes
Max bounce rate (suspension risk)	10%	AWS suspends sending at this level. Hard-bounce addresses must be removed from your list immediately.
Max complaint rate (safe)	Under 0.1%	Industry standard. AWS begins review above this level.
Max complaint rate (suspension risk)	0.5%	AWS suspends sending. Complaint addresses must be added to suppression list.
Verified identities per region	10,000	Combined email addresses and domains per AWS Region.

Rule of thumb: AWS SES has no 32K character wall. The only size constraint that matters in practice is the 80 KB Gmail clipping threshold. For a rich welcome email, this is generous but we can keep the file well under this limit if images are hosted externally (not embedded).

4. The Complete Rules — What To Do & What To Avoid

Rules inherited from the Salesforce Rulebook are marked OUTLOOK ONLY when they apply specifically because of Outlook's rendering engine — they are still mandatory if any recipients may be on Outlook. Given that keySkillset serves healthcare organisations with unknown client mix, treat all Outlook rules as REQUIRED unless you have confirmed your entire audience is on Gmail or Apple Mail.

Rule	Status	What breaks / why it matters
LAYOUT & STRUCTURE		
Use table-based layout (table, tr, td)	REQUIRED	Outlook uses Word's rendering engine and ignores div/flexbox/grid entirely. Layout collapses to unformatted single column.
Max email width: 600–620px	REQUIRED	Wider emails cause horizontal scrolling on mobile. Content gets clipped or misaligned on small screens.
Single-column layout	REQUIRED	Multi-column CSS layouts break in Outlook. Use nested tables for any multi-column structure.
Use role="presentation" on layout tables	REQUIRED	Screen readers announce table structure to users. Required for WCAG compliance and accessibility.
Use Flexbox or Grid for layout	FORBIDDEN	Outlook ignores both entirely. Gmail mobile has only partial support. Use table-based layout only.
Use div, section, article for layout	FORBIDDEN	Outlook's Word engine ignores div-based layouts. Everything stacks or collapses.
Use position, float, z-index, or clear	FORBIDDEN	Stripped by Outlook and Gmail. Elements overlap or disappear entirely.
Use HTML5 semantic elements	FORBIDDEN	Not supported in Outlook. Use table-based equivalents only.
CSS STYLING		
All critical CSS must be inline (style="...")	REQUIRED	Gmail strips <style> blocks. Outlook ignores class-based styles. All layout, colour, and font styles must be on each element directly.

Rule	Status	What breaks / why it matters
Add Outlook mso-table resets in <style> block	REQUIRED	Without mso-table-lspace/rspace:0pt, Outlook adds phantom gaps between table sections. Without #outlook a{padding:0}, Outlook pads all links.
Use rgba() or hsla() colours	FORBIDDEN	Outlook does not support rgba(). Text and backgrounds using rgba() become invisible or render as black. Convert all to solid hex.
Use CSS gradients (linear-gradient, radial-gradient)	FORBIDDEN	Outlook renders no gradient — falls back to solid colour or transparent. Replace with solid bgcolor on <td>.
Use CSS animations (@keyframes)	FORBIDDEN	Stripped by Outlook, Gmail, and Yahoo. Animations don't play and add to file size. Static design only.
Use pseudo-elements (::before / ::after)	FORBIDDEN	Not supported in any major email client. Elements using them simply do not render.
Use CSS background-image property	FORBIDDEN	Outlook strips CSS background images completely. Use bgcolor attribute on <td> for background colour.
Use JavaScript of any kind	FORBIDDEN	Stripped by all email clients. Email is a static medium. No exceptions.
Use font-weight above 700	FORBIDDEN	Outlook has no bold weight above 700. font-weight:800 or 900 is silently ignored — text renders as regular weight.
Use CSS shorthand properties (margin, padding, border)	CAUTION	Some clients only recognise individual properties. Write margin-top, margin-right etc. separately rather than margin: 0 0 8px 0.
Use box-shadow or text-shadow	CAUTION	Outlook ignores shadows. Safe to use for other clients but never rely on them for visual hierarchy.
Use border-radius	CAUTION	Outlook ignores border-radius — corners render as sharp squares. Visual only, layout is unaffected.
-webkit-background-clip: text (gradient text)	FORBIDDEN	Not supported in Outlook. Replace with solid colour text.
FONTS & TYPOGRAPHY		
Use web-safe fonts only (Arial, Georgia, Verdana, Helvetica)	REQUIRED	Custom fonts are ignored by Outlook, Gmail, and Yahoo. Text falls back to Times New Roman, breaking the design.
Minimum font size: 14px body text	REQUIRED	Smaller text is unreadable on mobile. iOS auto-scales small text upward, potentially breaking layout.
Line height: 1.5–1.7	REQUIRED	Tighter line height makes text cramped and difficult to read on mobile screens.
Left-align body text	REQUIRED	Centre-aligned long text and justified text reduce readability and fail WCAG 2.1 AA. Reserve centring for headlines and CTAs only.
Use Google Fonts or external @font-face	FORBIDDEN	Outlook and Gmail strip Google Fonts imports entirely. Only Apple Mail supports custom fonts. Always falls back to Times New Roman.
IMAGES & MEDIA		
Host all images on a publicly accessible CDN or S3 URL	REQUIRED	Unlike Salesforce, you are not required to use the Salesforce Content Library. Any public URL works — but it must be genuinely public. S3 bucket must have public read access.
Always set width attribute on <img>	REQUIRED	Outlook uses the image's natural size if no width is set — can cause oversized images that break layout.

Rule	Status	What breaks / why it matters
Always use height:auto in CSS — never hardcode height	REQUIRED	Hardcoding both width and height squishes the image. Always let height scale naturally.
Always include descriptive alt text on every <img>	REQUIRED	Many clients block images by default. Without alt text, recipients see a blank box. Fails WCAG 1.1.1.
Always add display:block to images	REQUIRED	Without display:block, images render inline and create phantom spacing below them in most clients.
For logo images: use PNG with opaque (non-transparent) background	REQUIRED	Logos with dark text on a transparent background become invisible in dark mode. Use a solid or contrasted background on the PNG.
Use base64-encoded images	FORBIDDEN	Dramatically increases file size. Many clients block base64 images as a security measure. Broken in Outlook. Never embed images as base64.
Use inline SVG elements	FORBIDDEN	SVG is not supported in Outlook desktop at all. Replace with PNG or text symbols.
Use CSS background-image for visible images	FORBIDDEN	Outlook strips CSS background images. Use <img> tags for all visible images, bgcolor for background colour only.
DARK MODE		
Add <meta name="color-scheme" content="light"> to <head>	REQUIRED	Without this, Apple Mail and some other clients apply full colour inversion by default, making your design unreadable.
Add <meta name="supported-color-schemes" content="light"> to <head>	REQUIRED	Required alongside color-scheme for Apple Mail to honour your light-mode intent.
Never use pure #000000 or #FFFFFF for critical text or backgrounds	CAUTION	Apple Mail fully inverts pure black and white regardless of contrast rules. Use near-equivalents: #000001 for black, #FFFFFE for white.
Avoid transparent PNG backgrounds if the image contains dark elements	REQUIRED	Dark text or icons on a transparent PNG background become invisible against dark-mode backgrounds. Export logo with an opaque background.
Test in actual dark mode inboxes, not browser preview	REQUIRED	Dark mode behaviour differs radically between Gmail app, Apple Mail, Outlook 365, and Outlook.com. Browser preview does not show dark mode rendering.
ACCESSIBILITY (WCAG 2.1 AA)		
Set lang attribute on <html> element (e.g. lang="en")	REQUIRED	Screen readers use the lang attribute to select the correct language for voice output. WCAG 3.1.1 failure without it.
Minimum colour contrast ratio: 4.5:1 for body text	REQUIRED	Fails WCAG 1.4.3 (Contrast Minimum). Text becomes unreadable for users with low vision or colour blindness. Verify with WebAIM Contrast Checker.
Minimum colour contrast ratio: 3:1 for large text (18px+ or 14px+ bold)	REQUIRED	Lower threshold for large text under WCAG 1.4.3 but still must be measured. Do not rely on "looks fine".
Never use colour as the sole method of conveying information	REQUIRED	Fails WCAG 1.4.1. Users with colour blindness cannot distinguish information presented only through colour. Pair colour with text or icons.
Add aria-label to CTA links that lack descriptive visible text	REQUIRED	Screen readers read link text aloud. "Click here" fails WCAG 2.4.6. Write aria-label="Set password and log in to keySkillset".
Minimum tap target size: 44 × 44px for buttons and links	REQUIRED	Smaller targets are difficult to tap on mobile. Fails WCAG 2.5.5. Always make CTA buttons at least 44px tall.

Rule	Status	What breaks / why it matters
Maintain 80:20 text-to-image ratio	REQUIRED	Screen readers cannot interpret image content. Emails that are mostly images exclude assistive technology users and trigger spam filters.
Use logical heading structure (h1, h2, h3)	REQUIRED	Screen readers navigate by heading structure. Skipping levels or using headings only for size creates confusing navigation for blind users.
Add aria-hidden="true" to decorative emoji or icons	CAUTION	Screen readers read out emoji names aloud (e.g. "party popper"). Decorative emoji should be hidden from assistive technology.
AWS SES TEMPLATE SYNTAX (HANDLEBARS)		
Use Handlebars syntax for all personalisation: {{variable}}	REQUIRED	SES templates use the Handlebars template system. Salesforce-style {{{Field_Name}}} syntax does not work. Use {{first_name}}, {{org_name}} etc.
Never put Handlebars variables inside CSS property values	FORBIDDEN	SES does not resolve Handlebars tags inside <style> blocks. The CSS will be rendered literally with the template token visible.
Never use Handlebars variables in image src="" URLs	CAUTION	Dynamic image URLs are unreliable. Host all images at fixed CDN or S3 URLs. Pass only text variables — never image paths — as Handlebars data.
Use {{#if variable}}...{{/if}} for optional sections	REQUIRED	If a variable is missing from the template data object, Handlebars renders nothing. Use conditionals for any field that may be null or absent.
Always provide a default or fallback for every variable	REQUIRED	A missing variable produces blank text or breaks layout. Use {{variable}} with fallback via {{#if}}...{{else}}Default text{{/if}}.
Escape user-generated content before passing to SES	REQUIRED	SES does not escape HTML in template variables. If your template data includes user input (e.g. names from a form), escape it server-side before passing to SES to prevent XSS.
Test templates with real data via SES SendTemplatedEmail	REQUIRED	Handlebars render failures only appear at send time. Always test with the actual JSON data object you pass at send time, not with placeholder text.
AWS SES INFRASTRUCTURE & DELIVERABILITY		
Configure SPF, DKIM, and DMARC on your sending domain before going live	REQUIRED	Without these, your emails fail authentication checks. Gmail and Yahoo reject unauthenticated bulk sends. SES makes DKIM setup straightforward via Easy DKIM.
Use a subdomain for SES sends (e.g. mail.keyskillset.com)	REQUIRED	Separates SES sender reputation from your main domain. A bad batch of emails cannot damage your primary domain's deliverability or reputation.
Move out of the SES sandbox before any production send	REQUIRED	Sandbox accounts are limited to 200 emails per 24 hours sent only to verified addresses. Request production access via AWS Support before going live.
Enable the account-level suppression list (BOUNCE + COMPLAINT)	REQUIRED	When enabled, SES automatically stops sending to addresses that have previously hard-bounced or complained. Without this, you keep hitting bad addresses and your bounce rate rises.
Wire SNS notifications for bounces and complaints to a handler	REQUIRED	SES will not call your code automatically. You must configure SNS topics for Bounce and Complaint events and subscribe a Lambda or webhook to add addresses to your suppression list.
Keep bounce rate below 5% and complaint rate below 0.1%	REQUIRED	AWS warns at 5% bounce and reviews/suspends at 10%. Complaint rate above 0.5% triggers

Rule	Status	What breaks / why it matters
		suspension. Monitor these in CloudWatch Reputation Metrics daily.
Use dedicated IP addresses if send volume is high	CAUTION	Shared SES IPs have accumulated reputation from all SES customers. At high volume (50K+ emails/month), dedicated IPs give you full control over your own sender reputation.
Set up CloudWatch alarms for bounce and complaint rates	REQUIRED	Without alarms, you will not know your rates are rising until AWS contacts you. Set alarms at 2.5% bounce and 0.05% complaint — half the warning thresholds.
MOBILE COMPATIBILITY		
Add viewport meta tag to <head>	REQUIRED	Without viewport meta, mobile clients render the email at desktop width and scale it down — text becomes unreadably small.
Add -webkit-text-size-adjust:100% to body CSS	REQUIRED	iOS automatically enlarges small text. This resets it and preserves the intended layout.
Add x-apple-disable-message-reformatting meta to <head>	REQUIRED	Without this, Apple Mail on iOS reformats the email — scaling and reflowing content unexpectedly.
Use @media query block for mobile overrides	REQUIRED	Without responsive overrides, desktop font sizes and padding are too large or small on mobile. Note: Gmail app strips media queries — ensure desktop styles are also readable on mobile.

5. What You Can Do on AWS SES That You Cannot on Salesforce

Because AWS SES has no 32K character wall, no tracking wrapper inflation, and no Salesforce Content Library constraint, you have significantly more creative headroom for signup, welcome, and onboarding emails. The following are explicitly permitted on AWS SES, provided the email remains under 80 KB total file size.

What you can now do	How to do it correctly
Richer, longer content	You are not fighting a 32K wall. Include more sections — platform walkthrough, feature highlights, support contact — without needing to aggressively strip content for size.
More sections and layout blocks	With no tracking wrapper inflation, a 25-section email can easily stay under 80 KB. Use nested tables to build multi-section layouts freely.
Images hosted anywhere	Host images on S3, Cloudinary, imgix, or any public CDN. No Salesforce Content Library required. Ensure the bucket or CDN is set to public read.
Handlebars conditionals and loops	Use {{#if org_name}}...{{/if}} to show or hide entire sections per user. Use {{#each courses}} to loop over dynamic content. This is not possible in standard Salesforce templates.
Richer personalisation	Pass a full JSON object as template data — user name, org name, assigned courses, manager name, deadline date. Handlebars renders it all inline at send time.
Inline SVG icons (non-Outlook recipients only)	If you are certain no recipients are on Outlook desktop, inline SVG is technically supported in Gmail, Apple Mail, and web clients. However: unknown audience means Outlook must be assumed. Use PNG fallbacks.
A/B testing via template variants	Create multiple SES templates (e.g. welcome_v1, welcome_v2) and split-test them at the application layer by varying which template name you pass

What you can now do	How to do it correctly
	to SendTemplatedEmail. SES has no native A/B split — this is done in your code.

On "being creative": The Outlook and Gmail rendering constraints are not Salesforce constraints — they are email client constraints. They apply on every send path. You can be creative with content, structure, personalisation, and length on AWS SES. You cannot be creative with CSS layout techniques (flexbox, gradients, animations, rgba()) because those break in Outlook regardless of whether you are sending through Salesforce, AWS, or a carrier pigeon.

6. What Breaks, Where & Why — Quick Reference

Symptom	Likely Cause	Client(s)	Fix
Layout collapses to single column	Using div/flexbox for layout	Outlook	Rebuild using nested tables only
Text is invisible on coloured background	rgba() colours used	Outlook	Replace all rgba() with solid hex equivalents
Background is flat or missing	CSS gradient used	Outlook	Use solid bgcolor on <td> instead
Logo shows broken image icon	URL wrong or not public	All clients	Host on public S3 or CDN, verify public read access
Logo is squished or stretched	Both width & height hardcoded on <img>	All clients	Set width attribute only; use height:auto in CSS
Email clipped "View entire message"	File over 102 KB	Gmail	Minify and remove unused sections. Target under 80 KB.
Fonts look different than expected	Custom or Google Font used	Outlook, Gmail	Use Arial, Georgia, Verdana only
Text appears in regular weight	font-weight:800 or 900 used	Outlook	Cap font-weight to 700
Gaps between table sections	mso-table resets missing	Outlook	Add mso-table-lspace:0pt; mso-table-rspace:0pt in <style>
Phantom space below images	No display:block on images	All clients	Always add display:block to all <img> tags
Animations not playing	@keyframes used	All clients	Remove animations — static design only
SVG not visible	Inline SVG used	Outlook	Replace with PNG or Unicode text symbols
Logo invisible in dark mode	Dark logo on transparent PNG	Apple Mail, Gmail iOS, Outlook	Export logo with opaque white or contrasted background
Handlebars token visible as literal text	Missing variable in template data JSON	SES render	Add {{#if}}...{{else}}Fallback{{/if}} guards for all variables
Template fails to send	Handlebars variable in template data missing entirely	SES API	Ensure every {{variable}} in the template exists in the TemplateData object
Bounce rate rising	Sending to invalid addresses / no suppression list	AWS SES account	Enable account-level suppression list. Wire SNS bounce handler.
SES account suspended	Bounce rate >10% or complaint rate >0.5%	AWS SES account	Set CloudWatch alarms at 50% of warning thresholds. Act immediately on bounce SNS events.

Symptom	Likely Cause	Client(s)	Fix
Low-contrast text fails audit	Colour contrast ratio below 4.5:1	All clients	Check all text/background combinations with WebAIM Contrast Checker
Screen reader reads emoji aloud	Decorative emoji not hidden	Screen readers	Add aria-hidden="true" to decorative emoji spans

7. Handlebars Template Syntax — Quick Reference

AWS SES uses the Handlebars templating system for all stored email templates (created via the CreateEmailTemplate API). Unlike Salesforce's flat merge field syntax, Handlebars supports conditionals, loops, and nested objects.

Basic Variable

```
<!-- In your HTML template -->
<p>Hi {{first_name}},</p>

<!-- In your TemplateData JSON -->
{ "first_name": "Jordan" }
```

Conditional — Show/Hide a Section

```
{{#if org_name}}
  <p>You have been enrolled by {{org_name}}.</p>
{{else}}
  <p>You have been enrolled in a training programme.</p>
{{/if}}
```

Nested Object

```
<!-- Template data -->
{ "user": { "first_name": "Jordan", "email": "jordan@example.com" } }

<!-- In template -->
<p>Hi {{user.first_name}}</p>
```

Loop — Iterating a List

```
<!-- Template data -->
{ "courses": [ { "name": "HIPAA Basics" }, { "name": "Workplace Safety" } ] }

<!-- In template -->
{{#each courses}}
  <tr><td>{{name}}</td></tr>
{{/each}}
```

Security note: SES does not escape HTML in Handlebars variables. If any variable comes from user input (e.g. a name typed during signup), escape it server-side before passing it in the TemplateData

JSON. Unescaped user input inside an email template is an XSS vector if the email is ever viewed in a web context.

8. Testing Workflow — Required Before Every Send

No email template should go to production before completing both checklists below. Browser preview does not replicate email client rendering. SES API preview does not replicate dark mode. You must test in actual inboxes.

8.1 — Pre-Build Checks

☐	Confirm all layout uses table, tr, td — no div, flexbox, or grid
☐	Confirm all CSS is inline on every element — no class-based styles
☐	Replace all rgba() colours with solid hex equivalents
☐	Remove all Google Fonts @import — use Arial/Helvetica stack
☐	Cap all font-weight values at 700
☐	Remove all inline SVG — replace with PNG or Unicode text symbols
☐	Remove all CSS animations and @keyframes
☐	Remove all ::before / ::after pseudo-elements
☐	Remove -webkit-background-clip: text gradient effects — use solid colour
☐	Add color-scheme and supported-color-schemes meta tags to <head>
☐	Add lang="en" attribute to <html> element
☐	Add aria-label attributes to all CTA links
☐	Add aria-hidden="true" to all decorative emoji
☐	Verify all Handlebars variables have {{#if}}...{{else}} fallbacks
☐	Confirm every {{variable}} in the template exists in the TemplateData JSON object
☐	Check all text/background contrast ratios using WebAIM Contrast Checker (minimum 4.5:1)
☐	Confirm logo PNG has an opaque (non-transparent) background
☐	Verify all image URLs are publicly accessible (S3 public read, CDN live)
☐	Confirm file size is under 80 KB to avoid Gmail clipping

8.2 — AWS SES Infrastructure Checks

☐	SPF record is configured on sending domain (mail.keyskillset.com)
☐	DKIM is enabled via Easy DKIM in SES console — all three CNAME records verified
☐	DMARC TXT record is set on sending domain

☐	SES account has been moved out of sandbox (production access granted)
☐	Account-level suppression list is enabled (BOUNCE + COMPLAINT reasons)
☐	SNS topics are created for Bounce and Complaint events
☐	Lambda or webhook is subscribed to SNS topics and adds addresses to suppression list
☐	CloudWatch alarms are set for bounce rate (warn at 2.5%) and complaint rate (warn at 0.05%)
☐	Template is uploaded to SES via CreateEmailTemplate API
☐	Template has been tested via SendTemplatedEmail with actual TemplateData JSON

8.3 — Email Client Testing

☐	Send test to Gmail (web) — verify layout, colours, images, and CTA link
☐	Send test to Outlook desktop (2019 or 365) — verify no layout collapse, no invisible text
☐	Send test to iPhone Mail — verify mobile layout and readability
☐	Enable dark mode on each test device and re-check every client
☐	Verify logo is visible in dark mode (no transparent background issue)
☐	Verify all Handlebars variables resolved — no literal tokens visible
☐	Verify CTA link is correct and functional end-to-end
☐	Run through Mail-Tester.com for spam score and SPF/DKIM/DMARC pass check
☐	Use Litmus or Email on Acid for cross-client rendering preview including Outlook 2013

8.4 — Recommended Testing Tools

Tool	What It Tests
AWS SES Send Test (built-in)	Renders Handlebars variables. Tests actual email delivery. Does not simulate email client rendering.
Mail-Tester.com (free)	Full spam score including SPF/DKIM/DMARC check, HTML quality, and content analysis.
Litmus (paid)	Preview in 90+ email clients — Outlook 2013/2016/2019/365, Gmail app, Apple Mail dark mode.
Email on Acid (paid)	Cross-client rendering, accessibility checker, dark mode preview, spam filter testing.
WebAIM Contrast Checker (free)	Checks text/background colour contrast against WCAG 2.1 AA (4.5:1 ratio minimum).
Parcel.io (free tier)	Real-time email code editor with dark mode preview. Faster than Litmus for rapid iteration.
AWS CloudWatch Reputation Metrics	Monitor live bounce rate and complaint rate against your SES account thresholds.

9. Quick Reference Cheatsheet

Always USE

- table, tr, td for all layout
- Inline CSS on every element: style="..."
- bgcolor attribute on td in addition to background-color in CSS
- width attribute on td and img
- valign attribute on td
- role="presentation" on layout tables
- display:block on all images
- height:auto in CSS for images
- Descriptive alt text on all images
- Web-safe fonts only: Arial, Helvetica, Georgia, Verdana
- Solid hex colours only — e.g. #0D2D6B, never rgba()
- font-weight: 700 maximum
- mso-table-lspace:0pt and mso-table-rspace:0pt in <style>
- Mobile @media query overrides
- color-scheme and supported-color-schemes meta tags
- lang="en" attribute on <html>
- aria-label on all CTA links
- aria-hidden="true" on all decorative emoji
- 4.5:1 minimum contrast ratio on all text
- Handlebars {{#if}}...{{else}}Fallback{{/if}} for every variable
- Server-side HTML escaping for all user-generated variable content
- Public CDN or S3 URL for all image hosting

Never USE

- div, section, article for layout
- display:flex, display:grid
- rgba() or hsla() for any colour
- CSS gradients (linear-gradient, radial-gradient)
- @keyframes or any CSS animations
- ::before or ::after pseudo-elements
- -webkit-background-clip: text
- Inline SVG elements
- base64-encoded images
- Google Fonts or any external @font-face
- font-weight: 800 or 900
- CSS background-image (use bgcolor on td instead)
- JavaScript of any kind
- position, float, z-index, or clear in CSS
- HTML5 semantic elements (section, article, aside, nav)
- Pure #000000 or #FFFFFF for critical text or backgrounds
- Transparent PNG backgrounds on logos or icons with dark elements

- Handlebars variables inside CSS property values
- Unescaped user-generated content in Handlebars template data

10. The Golden Rules

Rule 1: AWS SES removes the Salesforce size wall. It does not remove Outlook.

Rule 2: You can be creative with content and personalisation. You cannot be creative with CSS layout.

Rule 3: Every Handlebars variable needs a fallback. A missing variable in production is a broken email in production.

Rule 4: Wire your bounce and complaint handlers before going live. SES will suspend your account without warning if rates spike.

When in doubt: flat colour, web-safe font, hosted image, table layout. Same as always.

keySkillset — Internal Document — April 2026 — Companion to Salesforce Email Design Rulebook